

Article | 20 May 2026

Surging fuel costs risk creating new split in the eurozone

Higher fuel prices are hitting households across the eurozone. The impact on consumption, however, will be anything but uniform



With higher taxes, fuel prices in Italy are at the higher end of the scale in the eurozone.

The war in the Middle East has been going on for [almost three months](#) and disruptions to oil flows through the Strait of Hormuz have pushed prices sharply higher. While oil traded at around USD 70 per barrel at the end of February, prices have averaged roughly USD 110 since early March.

The oil price shock has quickly filtered through to households. Filling up has become noticeably more expensive across the eurozone, albeit to very different degrees. Compared with the week before the joint US-Israeli strike on Iran, the price of a 50-litre tank of unleaded petrol has risen by an average of between €5.00 in Spain and €13.50 in Germany. For diesel, the average increase has been even steeper, ranging from €15.65 in Italy to €23.00 in the Netherlands.

The biggest differences across eurozone countries were seen in late March and early April, coinciding with the spike in oil prices. Some of these gaps have since narrowed, partly due to temporary fiscal measures in several eurozone countries.

A slow burn for household budgets

If fuel prices were to remain at current levels for the rest of the year, annual fuel expenses would rise by roughly €70 in Italy and up to €280 for petrol in the Netherlands compared to

last year. For diesel, the additional burden would range from €190 to €430. And for those still remembering the 2022 energy price shock: annual fuel expenses (in nominal terms) in the eurozone would be between 2% (Austria) and 15% (the Netherlands) higher than in 2022.

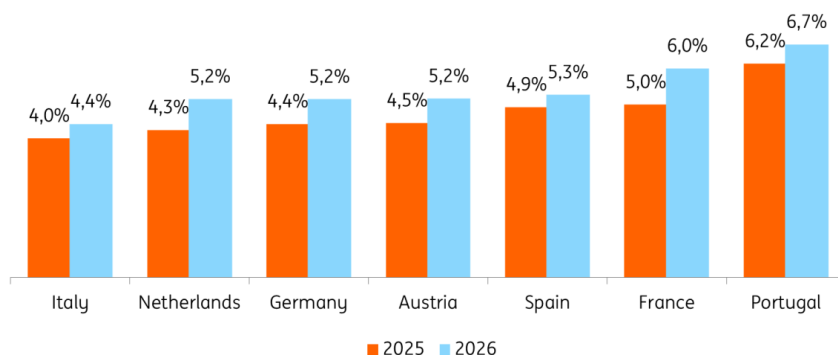
While this increase in fuel prices alone could undermine private consumption, it will do so more unevenly than many might think.

Across the eurozone, the share of disposable income spent on fuel differs markedly. Last year, households in Italy spent around 4.0% of their disposable income on fuel, compared with 6.2% in Portugal. Interestingly, this gap does not reflect cheaper fuel in Italy. On the contrary, with higher taxes, fuel prices there are at the higher end of the scale in the eurozone. The gap instead points to differences in driving habits, with Italians driving relatively few kilometres per year, and lower income levels in Portugal limiting the ability to absorb higher costs.

The increase in fuel prices so far, excluding any additional fiscal measures, is likely to widen the difference between eurozone countries in the share of disposable income spent on fuel. In the Netherlands, the sharpest absolute rise in fuel costs is pushing households to spend a much larger share of their disposable income on fuel than a year ago. Germany, France, and Austria, where people tend to drive more, are likely to face greater additional financial burdens as well, while Italy and Spain should see a more moderate increase. In Spain, the temporary reduction in the VAT rate on fuel from 21% to 10% dampens the price effect. In Italy, the below-average mileage is providing some relief.

Share of annual disposable income per capita spent on fuel

(in % of gross disposable income)



Source: European Commission; Odysee Mure; ING Economic & Financial Analysis; based on avg. fuel consumption of 7.35 l per 100 km; 2026 based on the assumption that the price from the 19th CW will apply for the rest of the year; European Commission forecast for disposable income per capita in 2026.

Why households won't be able to adapt quickly

In theory, households could try to cushion the shock by driving less. In practice, the experience of recent years suggests there is only limited room for that adjustment. Significant deviations from the long-term average only occurred during the pandemic years, when widespread working-from-home arrangements reduced the need to commute. Since then, mileage patterns have started to normalise, suggesting limited scope for households to offset higher prices by changing their driving habits. In fact, in most countries, average mileages are still very similar to pre-pandemic levels.

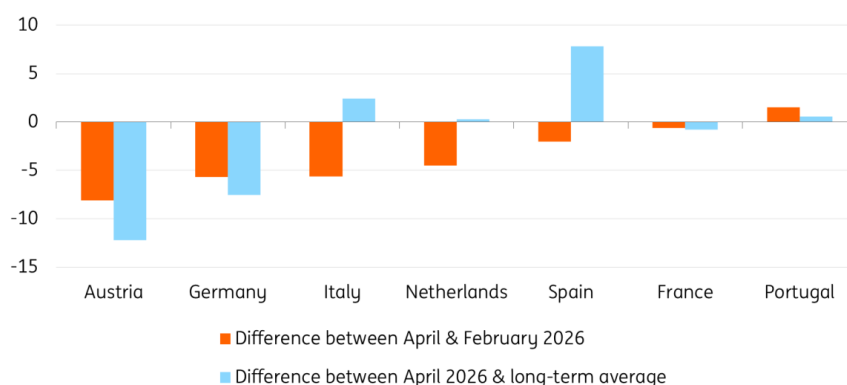
In other words: higher prices at the pump are more likely to hit consumption elsewhere than behaviour. As a result, higher fuel costs are likely to increasingly crowd out discretionary spending.

Higher gasoline prices fuel new divergence

This divergence in fuel price developments and the impact on disposable income is not just theoretical, it is already starting to show up in consumer sentiment. According to the latest European Commission survey, willingness to spend has dropped sharply in Germany and Austria – countries where disposable income is set to be among the hardest hit by rising fuel costs. Here, willingness to spend is also well below the long-term average.

DG ECFIN Consumer Survey: Change in willingness to spend

(Major purchases over the next 12 months; net balance)



Source: LSEG Datastream; ING Economic & Financial Analysis

Italy and Spain have also seen a decline, but spending intentions remain above their long-term averages. In France and Portugal, consumer appetite has so far held up relatively well – possibly because households there are already used to allocating a larger share of income to fuel.

Higher fuel prices are not only an energy story in the eurozone. They are quickly turning into a consumption story, and an increasingly asymmetric one. As households across the eurozone are forced to spend more at the pump, cutting down on other discretionary spending will diverge sharply across countries.

Author

Carsten Brzeski

Global Head of Macro

carsten.brzeski@ing.de

Franziska Biehl

Senior Economist, Germany

Franziska.Marie.Biehl@ing.de

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Article | 15 May 2026

THINK Ahead: Politics meets the bond market (again...)

Not for the first time, it's Britain leading the way in what has been a grim week for the global bond market. Political drama is back, interest rate expectations are rising. But for all the noise, James Smith argues there are limits on how much politics is likely to drive central banks this year. Read on as he and the team look ahead to another busy week in markets



The UK's Mayor of Manchester Andy Burnham has his sights set on Downing Street

Politics meets the bond market (again...)

Let's face it: nobody does political drama quite like Britain. In a competitive field of big global stories – a global energy crisis, a meeting of two superpowers – the limelight has still somehow found its way back to London.

In case you're struggling to keep up (and who can blame you), the ruling Labour Party is in the midst of a leadership struggle. Prime Minister Keir Starmer, though still in office, is under existential pressure after poor local election results. A leadership contest looks increasingly inevitable. And if you believe the betting markets, Manchester Mayor Andy Burnham is the man to beat.

All of this has unfolded against the backdrop of a grim week for global bond markets. The UK's 10-year yield rose by more than a quarter of a percentage point. But Britain is hardly alone. US yields are up around 20bp this week, while Germany's are higher by roughly 13bp.

That's an important reminder. For all the noise coming out of Westminster, it is still oil prices – and the outlook for global central banks – that are doing the heavy lifting for interest rates, both at the short and long end.

Of course, politics could matter more from here. There is [certainly scope for gilt yields to rise further](#) on domestic drama. But in practice, will politics really be a central driver of central bank decisions this year?

When it comes to Britain, I think it's important to keep things in proportion.

Yes, the political centre of gravity is likely to shift left. And yes, there is pressure to adapt the fiscal rules. But politicians across the spectrum are presumably acutely aware there are limits, with the shadow of the 2022 “mini-budget” crisis still hanging over Westminster.

Where leadership hopefuls are talking about higher borrowing, the emphasis is overwhelmingly on investment – particularly capital-intensive areas such as defence and social housing. In practice, we suspect any additional borrowing, if it materialises, is unlikely to exceed £15–20bn per year.

That is not trivial. And investors would no doubt start to question the UK's longer-term commitment to fiscal restraint, particularly as we edge closer to what could be a challenging 2029 general election.

But that is not quite the question facing the Bank of England.

The Bank needs to judge whether a modest fiscal pivot of this kind would materially boost inflation over a two-year horizon. And if it's going to be centred on investment, it's worth recalling that Britain's recent track record of actually building things is... not great.

Private housebuilding is almost 20% below its pre-Covid level. Firms consistently cite planning constraints and regulation as key bottlenecks. Britain's infrastructure delivery record is no more inspiring.

That suggests any fiscal boost is unlikely to move the dial much for the Bank of England in the near term, particularly when you remember the next Budget isn't due until late Autumn. And with investment, there is always the counter-question of how much it lifts the supply side of the economy and productivity, offsetting any inflationary impulse.

If you want a cautionary tale, look at Germany. Optimism last spring around vast defence and infrastructure spending faded quickly as it became clear that this was not something that

would happen overnight.

A year on, there are some signs of progress. Defence spending, for example, began to pick up late last year. Carsten Brzeski [argues](#) the impulse is now “real”, with effects increasingly likely to show through this year and next – energy crisis notwithstanding.

Which brings us neatly back to energy.

When it comes to politics and its relationship with central banks, the far bigger question is whether governments across Europe are forced into much larger support packages than we have seen so far. The fuel tax cuts announced in various countries are small beer compared with the 2–3% of GDP packages rolled out in 2022. That, in no small part, was why central banks across Europe were forced into steep rate hikes four years ago.

Whether similar pressure builds again this time will depend, above all, on where energy prices go next. You can find our scenarios in the latest [ING Monthly](#), or listen back to Warren Patterson walking through his outlook in our [recent webinar](#).

Two points from that discussion stand out.

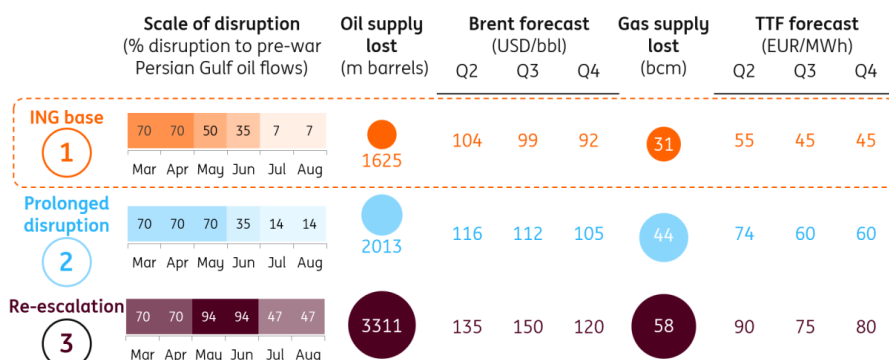
First, even if the war were to end tomorrow, energy prices may not fall as far as many expect. Significant drawdowns in oil inventories are likely to keep upward pressure on prices for some time yet.

Second, natural gas prices currently look too low. There is meaningful upside risk if disruptions persist into the third quarter, particularly as competition intensifies between Asian and European buyers for LNG.

It's a reminder that, for all the political noise, its energy prices will remain the dominant force for central banks. It's why we're expecting rate hikes from the Bank of England and European Central Bank in June, and why we no longer expect a Federal Reserve rate cut until December.

James Smith

Three scenarios for global energy markets



Source: ING

THINK Ahead in developed markets

United States (James Knightley)

- **Housing starts** (Thu): It is a quiet week for US data, with a focus on housing numbers. High prices and elevated mortgage rates are an obvious headwind that is hurting affordability and depressing activity. We will also have the FOMC minutes, which will underscore the hawkish shift seen in April when three members wanted more neutral language on where interest rates may head.

United Kingdom (James Smith)

- **Inflation** (Wed): Headline inflation is actually likely to dip in April's data, due next week. That might sound strange as energy prices surge. But the timing of Easter is set to temporarily push down on CPI. So too will the fact that many of last year's administrative/regulatory price hikes weren't repeated at the start of this financial year – or not to the same extent. We're also looking for signs that lower wage growth and greater economic slack results in more muted annual price hikes across the service sector. If we're right, that should make some Bank of England officials more relaxed about the risk of second-round effects from the current energy crisis.

THINK Ahead in Central and Eastern Europe

Poland (Adam Antoniak)

- **Industry** (Thu): Activity in industry is on a roller-coaster ride. Following subdued output in the first two months due to harsh weather, industry rebounded sharply in March. Still, the general trend is far from positive. Industry has been nearly stagnant in recent years and weak external demand along with mounting competitive pressure from China poses a challenge for some sectors. At the same time, the Middle East conflict and unfolding

energy crisis imposed yet another layer of risks and uncertainty. We expect the recovery in manufacturing to lose momentum ahead, even if short-term performance might be boosted by stockpiling. Upward pressure from energy commodities probably lifted PPI from over two-year-long deflation.

- **Labour market** (Thu): Wage growth continues its downward trend as the situation normalises after double-digit growth in 2023-24. In April, the lower annual dynamic was also probably facilitated by a high reference base due to high growth in mining. Employment in enterprises continues shrinking at a pace nearing 1% year-on-year as declining labour supply is facing somewhat softer demand.

Hungary (Peter Virovacz)

- **Wages** (Wed): It is hard to imagine anything stealing the limelight from the political headlines in Hungary nowadays. However, the ongoing issue of high wage growth would certainly exacerbate the complicated situation of the National Bank of Hungary. Strong real wage growth and rising consumer confidence could increase pipeline price pressure on top of the energy price shock. Meanwhile, the movement of the forint towards territory that would prompt the central bank to consider a dovish pivot sooner than expected is adding spice to the situation.

Czech Republic (David Havrlant)

- **PPI** (Wed): Higher oil and natural gas prices continued to pass through to producer pricing, when annual price dynamics in industry likely switched to positive territory in April, following more than a year of annual declines. This will further foster pressures on consumer prices, where goods price gains quickened in April.

Key events in developed markets next week

Country	Time Data/event	ING	Prev.
Monday 18 May			
Italy	0900 Mar Global Trade Balance (EUR bn)	-	4.9
Tuesday 19 May			
US	1330 May 2 ADP weekly employment change (000s)	20	33
	1500 Apr pending home sales (MoM%)	1.1	1.5
Eurozone	1000 Mar Total Trade Balance SA (EUR bn)	-	7
UK	0700 Mar ILO Unemployment Rate	4.9	4.9
	0700 Mar Employment Change (000s)	160	25
	0700 Mar Average Weekly Earnings (3M YoY%)	3.7	3.8
	0700 Mar Average Weekly Earnings ex Bonus (3M YoY%)	3.5	3.6
Canada	1330 Apr CPI (MoM%/YoY%)	0.8/3.3	0.9/2.4
	1330 Apr Core CPI (MoM%/YoY%)	-/-	0.2/2.5
Netherlands	0530 Mar Trade Balance (EUR bn)	-	9.9
Wednesday 20 May			
US	1900 FOMC Minutes	-	-
Eurozone	1000 Apr CPI (YoY%)	-	2.2
UK	0700 Apr Core CPI (YoY%)	2.6	3.1
	0700 Apr CPI (MoM%/YoY%)	1.0/3.0	0.7/3.3
	0700 Apr Services CPI (YoY%)	3.4	4.5
Thursday 21 May			
US	1330 Initial Jobless Claims (000s)	215	211
	1330 Apr Housing Starts (000s)	1410	1502
Eurozone	0900 Mar Current Account SA (EUR bn)	-	24.9
	0900 May HCOB Manufacturing PMI Flash	-	52.2
	0900 May HCOB Services PMI Flash	-	47.6
	0900 May HCOB Composite PMI Flash	-	48.8
	1500 May Consumer Confidence Flash	-	-20.6
Germany	0830 May HCOB Manufacturing PMI Flash	50.8	51.4
	0830 May HCOB Service PMI Flash	46	46.9
	0830 May HCOB Composite PMI Flash	47.8	48.4
France	0815 May HCOB Composite PMI Flash	-	47.6
UK	0930 May S&P Global Composite PMI Flash	-	52.6
	0930 May S&P Global Manufacturing PMI Flash	-	53.7
	0930 May S&P Global Services PMI Flash	-	52.7
Sweden	0700 Apr Unemployment Rate	-	9.7
Friday 22 May			
US	1500 May Michigan Sentiment Final	48.2	48.2
Germany	0700 Q1 GDP Detailed (QoQ%/YoY%)	0.2/0.4	0.3/0.5
	0700 Jun GfK Consumer Sentiment	-35	-33.3
	0900 May Ifo Business Climate	83.8	84.4
	0900 May Ifo Current Conditions	84.5	85.4
	0900 May Ifo Expectations	83.1	83.3
UK	0700 Apr Retail Sales (MoM%/YoY%)	-/-	0.7/1.7
Canada	1330 Mar Retail Sales (MoM%)	-	0.7

Source: Refinitiv, ING

Key events in EMEA next week

Country	Time (BST) Data/event	ING	Prev.
Monday 18 May			
Poland	1300 Apr Core Inflation (YoY%)	2.9	2.7
Romania	1100 Mar Current Account (EUR bn)	-	2.3
Wednesday 20 May			
Hungary	0730 Mar Average Gross Wages (YoY%)	9.0	9.7
Czech Rep	800 Apr PPI (MoM%/YoY%)	1.0/0.7	1.5/-1.1
Thursday 21 May			
Poland	0830 Apr Employment (YoY%)	-0.9	-0.9
	0830 Apr Wages (YoY%)	5.9	6.6
	0830 Apr Industrial Output (YoY%)	2.4	9.4
	0830 Apr PPI (YoY%)	0.2	-0.8
Friday 22 May			
Turkey	0800 Apr Trade Balance (USD bn)	-8.5	-11.2

Source: Refinitiv, ING

Author

James Smith

Developed Markets Economist, UK
james.smith@ing.com

James Knightley

Chief International Economist, US
james.knightley@ing.com

Adam Antoniak

Senior Economist, Poland
adam.antoniak@ing.pl

Peter Virovacz

Chief Economist, Hungary
peter.virovacz@ing.com

David Havrlant

Chief Economist, Czech Republic
420 770 321 486
david.havrlant@ing.com

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COMMODITIES, FOOD & AGRI ENERGY

Sitting, waiting, wishing... for energy flows to resume

Energy markets remain extremely sensitive to developments in the Middle East, showing the significance of the supply disruptions we are witnessing. However, there have been several factors that have helped to take some pressure off prices



With no imminent peace deal in sight, stalled Hormuz flows continue to hold Brent above \$100/bbl

Falling Chinese imports and rising US exports offer relief to oil markets

It has been another volatile month in energy markets, with oil prices being whipsawed by Iran-related headlines. Cold water has been thrown over optimism for an imminent peace deal, after President Trump rejected Iran's counterproposal peace plan. And as a result, any hopes for a quick resumption in energy flows through the Strait of Hormuz have also faded, which has seen Brent trade convincingly back above \$100/bbl.

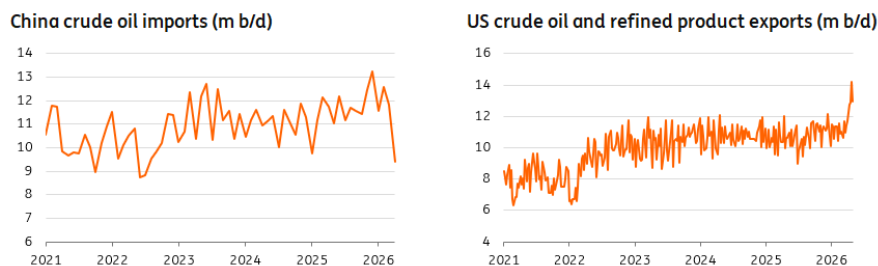
However, with the oil market facing a supply disruption of around 13m b/d, one may be surprised that we are not seeing much higher prices. There is an element of the market still clinging to some optimism that energy flows may start picking up. However, there are some fundamental factors that have also helped. Chinese oil imports have fallen significantly, while

US oil exports hit record levels consistently in April, which has helped to take some of the upward pressure off the market. But these are temporary solutions. China will be relying on inventory as imports fall, while similarly the growth in US exports is fed by inventory rather than supply growth.

Another element which has contained the market is that we have already started to see demand destruction in the oil market. Crude oil prices have not had to go as high as many would imagine to drive this decline in demand. This can be largely attributed to the relative strength seen in refined product prices (gasoline, diesel, jet fuel), reflected by the widening in refined product margins. The significant strength in refined product prices has meant that crude oil prices have not had to go as high to ensure demand destruction.

While there is still plenty of uncertainty over how the situation plays out, we are assuming some recovery in oil flows in the remainder of the second quarter, allowing for nearer to normal flows in the third quarter. Under this scenario, Brent averages \$104/bbl in 2Q26 and US\$92/bbl in 4Q26. Clearly, though, every day that goes by without a resolution pushes the market towards a much more aggressive scenario.

Chinese oil imports fall while US oil exports surge amid Persian Gulf supply disruptions



Source: China Customs, EIA, ING Research

Demand destruction keeps the gas market in check... for now

While European gas prices are trading above pre-Iran war levels, they have come off significantly from their peak following the start of the war. We believe that gas markets are underpricing the scale of the supply disruption. The gas market has less of a buffer to weather supply shocks, while there is little in the way of alternative routes for Persian Gulf LNG to move to its destination, other than going through the Strait of Hormuz. While ship tracking data shows that Qatar has shipped its first two LNG cargoes since the start of the war, this falls far short of normal flows.

There is not enough slack in the LNG market to offset these supply losses, so the market will have to rely on inventory and demand destruction to try to balance, which is what we have been seeing. In Asia, gas-to-coal switching is occurring within the power sector, while industrial

demand is also coming under pressure. Meanwhile, relying on inventories means that buyers will have to come back to the market at a later stage to restock. The big upside risk for the market is if this restocking has to happen before energy flows through the Strait of Hormuz resume.

If we see Asian buyers coming into the spot LNG market to refill inventory/offset disrupted contracted volumes, this will increase competition between Europe and Asia for cargoes, which would push prices higher.

Gas storage in the EU is relatively tight, at 35% full compared to a five-year average of 48%. This will make the job of refilling storage tougher, especially as the TTF forward curve – currently in backwardation – does not incentivise storage. More flexibility in EU storage targets helps to take some pressure off the market heading into the 2026/27 winter. However, going into the winter with 75% full storage (which is the minimum allowed under extreme conditions) would leave the European market more vulnerable through the winter and risk higher prices.

Author

Warren Patterson

Head of Commodities Strategy

Warren.Patterson@ing.com

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